

Financial Services Implementation Case Study

Document Information

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Executive Summary

This case study illustrates how a representative mid-size financial services organization implemented enterprise data governance to address regulatory reporting risk, fragmented customer data, and slow audit cycles. It is intended as an illustrative reference — adapt the specifics to your own organization's context.

Organization Profile: Regional bank / financial services firm, ~5,000 employees, multiple lines of business (retail banking, lending, wealth management).

1. Business Context

1.1 The Challenge

- Customer data was fragmented across core banking, CRM, and loan origination systems with no single source of truth
- Regulatory reporting (call reports, AML/KYC filings) required weeks of manual reconciliation each quarter
- No formal data ownership meant data quality issues were discovered by auditors rather than internal teams
- Risk and compliance teams lacked confidence in the lineage of figures used in regulatory submissions

1.2 Regulatory Drivers

- Bank Secrecy Act (BSA) / Anti-Money Laundering (AML) reporting accuracy requirements
- Examiner expectations around data lineage and control documentation (e.g., BCBS 239 principles)
- State and federal consumer protection requirements for accurate customer data handling

2. Governance Approach

2.1 Program Structure

The organization stood up a Data Governance Council chaired by the Chief Risk Officer, with the Chief Data Officer leading day-to-day execution — mirroring the structure in the Data Governance Charter Template.

2.2 Phased Rollout

1. **Foundation (Months 1-3):** Charter approval, policy development, classification scheme tailored to regulated financial data
2. **Pilot (Months 4-6):** Customer Master Data domain selected as pilot — highest regulatory visibility and cross-system fragmentation
3. **Expansion (Months 7-12):** Extended to lending and AML/transaction monitoring data domains
4. **Operationalization (Months 13-18):** Embedded governance metrics into quarterly risk committee reporting

2.3 Key Capabilities Implemented

- Enterprise data catalog covering core banking, CRM, and loan systems
- Automated lineage tracking from source systems through to regulatory reports
- Data quality rules targeting Critical Data Elements used in AML and call report submissions
- Formal Business and Technical Data Steward assignments per domain

3. Results

Metric	Before	After (18 Months)
Quarterly regulatory reconciliation time	3 weeks	4 days
Customer data duplicate rate	~12%	<2%
Critical Data Elements with assigned steward	0%	94%
Audit findings related to data lineage	6 (prior cycle)	1

4. What Worked Well

- Starting with the highest-risk, highest-visibility domain (customer master data) built credibility quickly
- Embedding governance metrics directly into existing risk committee reporting avoided creating a parallel reporting track
- Pairing every new policy with an automated quality rule reduced reliance on manual spot-checks

5. Challenges Encountered

- Legacy core banking system lacked accessible metadata, requiring manual schema documentation in early phases
 - Initial resistance from loan origination teams who viewed governance as "more compliance overhead" — addressed through targeted change management (see Change Management Toolkit)
 - Underestimated the effort required for AML transaction data lineage given the complexity of upstream feeds
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6. Lessons for Other Financial Services Organizations

- Align governance milestones with existing regulatory reporting cycles to demonstrate value where examiners are already looking
 - Treat data lineage as a control, not just documentation — examiners increasingly expect it to be demonstrable on demand
 - Invest early in steward training for AML/risk domains, where data quality has direct financial and legal consequences
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Document Control:

- This is an illustrative template case study for adaptation to your organization
- Replace illustrative metrics and details with your own organization's data before external use
- Pair with Lessons Learned materials and the GDPR/HIPAA/SOX compliance templates in Section 07